NARI SHAKTI ACT

ensured that the fight is no longer merely over when women should get 33 per cent reservation. It has now seemingly linked it to a larger and far more volatile struggle over delimitation, Census, caste enumeration, claims of the Other Backward Classes (OBCs), the anxieties of the southern states—in short, the basic arithmetic of power in any future Lok Sabha.

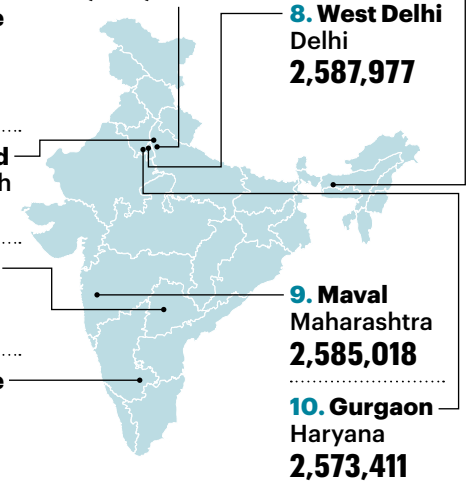
Meanwhile, every party agrees that reserving 33 per cent of Lok Sabha seats for women is an imperative that needs speedy implementation. The bigger problem is how to break the impasse over women's representation in Parliament without allowing it to get derailed by other contentious issues. Here, we attempt some answers to the big questions:

Q. WHY DID AN EXPANDED LOK SABHA OF 850 SEATS NOT PASS MUSTER?

Experts say the infirmity in the constitutional amendment bill was not that it chose 850 seats for the expanded Lok Sabha, but that there was no written justification in the bill on how it arrived at the number. On the floor, Shah tried to settle the southern states' nerves with a formula the bill did not contain. Every state's current Lok Sabha allocation, he said, would rise uniformly by 50 per cent, preserving the share of each state. The southern bloc's 24 per cent would thus stay 24 per cent. The home minister also pointed out that the five southern states stood to gain 19 more seats under the 50 per cent formula when compared to applying the 2011 Census as the basis. When Opposition MPs pointed out that the bill itself lacked any such assurance, Shah took the unusual step of offering an hour's adjournment to insert the formula into the text.

Rajya Sabha MP Kapil Sibal put his finger on the problem that the Opposition found with Shah's formula. A 50 per cent uniform hike, he argued, would in fact widen the absolute gap between the northern and southern states rather than narrow it. The 80 seats in Uttar Pradesh, for instance, would rise to 120; Tamil Nadu's 39 would rise to only 59. The difference between UP and Tamil Nadu, which is 41 seats today, would grow to 61. Sibal did not stop at the arithmetic, he also connected it to the electoral map: in the northern belt, the BJP had won 127 out of 238 Lok Sabha seats in 2024; in the five southern states and the Union territories below the Vindhyas, it won 29 out of 130. The absolute expansion of the Hindi heartland's numerical

10 Lok Sabha seats with highest voters



The population of Malkajgiri is 6,441% more than Lakshadweep. Yet both seats are represented by a single MP

10 Lok Sabha seats with lowest voters

